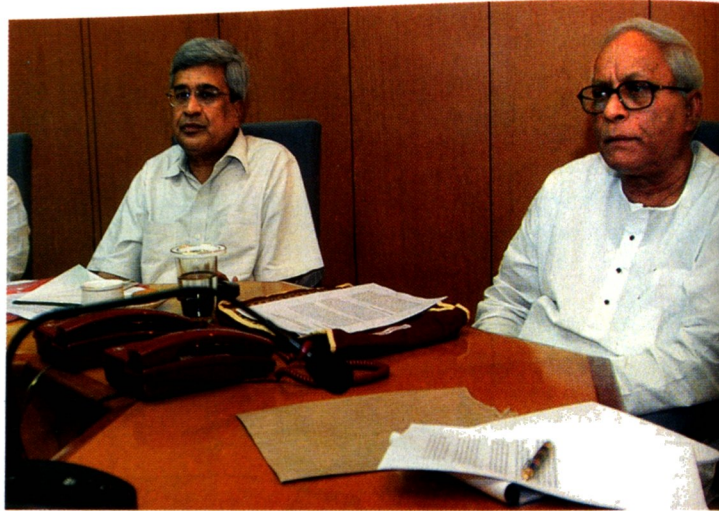


Bhattacharya spoke about the benefits of nuclear energy at a CII national council meeting in Kolkata. US treasury secretary Henry Paulson even pushed the American line on the agreement with Bhattacharya during his visit to Kolkata two weeks ago. Michigan-based Dow Chemicals, now owner of the infamous Union Carbide, is keen to invest in West Bengal. The Bhopal Gas tragedy does not haunt the chief minister. Dow Chemicals, which made Napalm and Agent Orange for the US Army during the Vietnam War, is no longer a problem for his new-age Communist conscience. "Vietnam has American investors too," was his explanation. Says Partha Chatterjee, Trinamool Congress leader, "This is the Marxists' strategy to stay in power at any cost. They are unashamed of their double standards."

In his seventh year in the Writer's Building, the Presidency College graduate's craftily cultivated pragmatism is under scrutiny. He had won the 2006 Assembly elections selling "the resurgence of Bengal" to voters and even CPI(M) critics in urban Bengal had hoped Bhattacharya would deliver. Despite his aggressiveness within the party, the story of Bengal's development is superficial. "His idea of private investment is only shopping malls, restaurant chains and branded clothes," Pradip Bhattacharya, working president of the West Bengal Pradesh Congress Committee (WBPCC) said. The Tatas' small car factory is coming up in Singur but the area continues to be flooded every monsoon. Minor incidents of violence take place everyday in and around the factory area, including attempts to bring down the walls as a mark of protest. Nandigram hasn't even witnessed the industrialisation that was promised to it, despite the loss of human lives on March 14 this year, the killing of 14 villagers for which no action has been initiated against the police officers involved. Embarrassed by his handling of the Nandigram situation, his party had released a propaganda film titled *Aasman ki talash mein* (In Search of the Sky) earlier this year. Made by a member of the CPI(M) students' unit SFI, the film unabashedly blamed the Trinamool Congress for inciting terror in Nandigram. The disproportionate use of force by the



CORNERED: CPI(M) bosses like Karat (L) and Basu (R), are upset with Bhattacharya's handling of issues like Singur (below) and Nandigram (bottom)

